Aetas Obscura

The Darkening Age · Player's Book

A Setting for The 2d12 System, Version 2

SkroxiousDM
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Part 1
Prologue

Chapter 1: Using This Book

The Western Empire is gone — but in the year 500 most people do not quite believe it yet. Roman roads still carry the post. Roman law is still cited in Gothic courts. The Senate still meets. Beneath that brittle surface a hidden world of wizards, blood-drinkers, faerie Queens and starving gods is fighting over the bones of an age. This is **Aetas Obscura**, the Darkening Age.

This is the **Player's Book**. It gives you the world as your characters know it, the hidden powers as an informed person hears of them, and the rules you need to play. It does not replace the core rules.

What You Need

- **The 2d12 System, Version 2 — Core Rulebook.** Every rule here assumes it: the 2d12 roll, Difficulties, Power and Effects, statuses, Resistance, Momentum and Woe, Truths, and scripted conflicts.
- **The core Descriptors, Playbooks and Focuses.** This book adds no new Playbooks or Focuses. The chapter **Characters of the Age** shows how to dress the core ones for the year 500.

How the Book Is Organised

- **Part I — The Darkening Age** is the world: the premise, the map, what the learned teach about reality, the Concordat, the hidden powers, the magi of the age, famous places and the timeline.
- **Part II — Rules of the Hidden World** is the rules you use: campaign Truths, skills, origins, magic, worship, the Seven Seals, horror and taint, the Veiled Sphere, the blood-drinkers, oaths, setting conflicts and Truths.
- **Appendices** open with the **Player Primer**, the world in its own voice, then the glossary and a quick reference.

What This Book Doesn't Tell You

Everything here is something a well-read, well-travelled character could know or has heard. Much of it is rumour, teaching and reputation, and some of it is wrong. What the hidden powers really are, what they really want, and how the world really works is the story you will find at the table. The GM has a separate **Setting Book**. Please don't read it.

Terminology

This book uses the house names of the 2d12 System throughout.

Generic	House name	In the fiction
Threat	**Wœ**	The GM's pool; the weight of the world pressing back
Fate	**Tychē**	Fortune; the favour of whatever is listening
Momentum	**Momentum**	The party's shared advantage
Vitality	**Sōma**	Body
Alacrity	**Akmē**	Vigour and the peak of action
Mind	**Psychē**	Mind and memory
Spirit	**Pneuma**	Breath, will, and magical potential

The pool names are not decoration in this setting. **Pneuma** is the breath and will a magus spends to name the world (see **The Art of Names**), and the thing a long vigil at the altar leaves you short of.

Notation

- **Difficulties:** Easy 12, Standard 15, Hard 18, Formidable 21, Heroic 24.
- **Statuses** are written *name-tier*: *shaken-2*, *nemesion-3*.
- **Clocks** are written as segments: a 6-clock, a 4-clock.
- ⋆ marks an ability that costs Refresh, as in the core rules.

- **§** references point to the core rulebook unless they name this book.

Sources

This book is the player-facing edition of the **Aetas Obscura Setting Book**, and follows the **Player Primer** (reprinted, lightly edited, as the first appendix) for what characters know.

Part 2
The Darkening Age

Chapter 1: The Premise

> "The world is ending. It has been ending for a hundred years. The legions are gone, the gods are starving, and beneath the cracks in Rome the older things stir. We Sealed Ones have a name for this age: *Ætas Obscura*, the Darkening Age. We tell our students that we work to hold back the night. We do not tell them that the night has already swallowed half the lamps."
>
> — attributed to Theognostos of Smyrna, Magister of the Inner Seal, c. 497

It is the Year of the Consulship of Patricius and Hypatius — *Anno Diocletiani* 217, *Anno Domini* 500. The Western Empire died a generation ago. Constantinople rules a brittle East. Persia waits across the Euphrates. Goths, Franks and Burgundians scrabble over Roman bones. The old gods are dying — but they are not dead, and what is replacing them is not always Christ.

The hidden world is **more visible** now than it will ever be again. Wizards walk into Senate halls. Vampires hold Roman magistracies. Faerie embassies attend imperial weddings. The Church has not yet finished its long campaign to scour magic from the world, and the Concord of the Seven Seals — the wizards' council of the age — still keeps its hidden library beneath a Bithynian fort.

Beneath the political theatre, something far worse is stirring. The Outer Ones — *Hoi Exō*, "those from outside" — press against the cracks in reality. A black pharaoh's cult has woken after a thousand-year sleep. Deep Ones swim again in the Tyrrhenian. The Yithians, scholars of time, are recording the end of something.

The Darkening Age is not a metaphor.

Design Pillars

- **The gods are real.** Prayers sometimes work. Rites performed correctly produce results. Gods can be pleased, displeased, distracted and weakened. What they really are is a question your characters may one day answer.
- **Politics over plumbing.** Every faction has factions inside it. Every great power has a successor scheming.
- **Cosmic horror with stakes.** The Mythos is real and unwinnable on its own terms, but human-scale victories matter. You cannot save the world. You can save your village, your apprentice, your friend.
- **Late antiquity as a character.** Real places, real polities, real religions, used as the bones of the setting — then twisted.

What the Characters Are

The characters are people who have seen behind the curtain and cannot stop seeing. Typical parties include:

- a **Concord cell** — an apprentice under the Sword of Damocles, a Stylite, a physician of the School of Alexandria, and a fixer who knows the Senate;
- a **Court's retinue** — a mortal sworn to a faerie Queen, her bargained-for servants, and a priest who should not be keeping such company;
- **hunters** — a Fellowship of the Lance veteran, a Marian widow whose prayers are answered, and a scholar who has read too much Hesiod;
- **the compromised** — a Lamia's thrall who broke free, a Gnostic courier, a Deep One hybrid who has not yet begun to change.

Tone

Play the year 500 as a world of **provisional** things. Every institution is still standing and every one of them is hollow. The characters can win the scene, the city, even the decade. They cannot make the dark go away. Horror lands hardest when the table cares about something small that the dark can take.

Campaign Frames

Frame	What the characters do
Under the Seal	Concord agents on probation, sent where the Inner Seal will not go itself. Patron: Damaskios or Bœtius.
The Knight's Road	The retinue of a Court's mortal Knight, collecting debts and keeping the Mantle from being stolen.
The Blue Mantle	Hunters caught in the war between Mormo's sects and the Marian hunters who wear the Madonna's blue.
The Long Watch	A cell hunting the Brotherhood of the Black Pharaoh before its patient work comes due.
Last Roman	Sub-Roman Britain with Ambrosius Aurelianus: Saxons, Strigoi, the druid-lord Drest, and Long Night's gates.
Ērānšahr	Persia under Kavad and the Mazdakites, among the fire-priests of the Mobedān.

Chapter 2: The World in 500 AD

A brief tour, west to east, of the map your players will move across.

Region	Mortal power	Hidden powers most active
Britannia	Sub-Roman warlords; rising Saxon kingdoms	Court of Long Night; Strigoi allied with Picts; the druid-lord Drest
Gaul	Franks under Clovis (Catholic since 496); Burgundians; Visigoths	Burning Crown; Concord chapter at Tolosa
Hispania	Visigothic kingdom (Arian)	Hounds of Set raiding-trails; ancient Iberian Free Folk
Italy	Ostrogoths under Theodoric, ruling from Ravenna	House of Lamia; Concord chapter at Rome; Mormo's catacomb cabals
North Africa	Vandals under Thrasamund (Arian; persecutes Catholics)	Hounds of Set (seat at Carthage); Brotherhood in the deep desert
Balkans	Eastern provinces raided by Bulgars and Slavs	Strigoi homeland in Dacia
Constantinople	Anastasius I, an old and careful man	Concord's largest chapter; Lamia diaspora; the Inner Seal's eastern chancery
Anatolia and Syria	Chalcedonian and Miaphysite strife	Concord and theurgic schools; Order of Dagon on the Lebanese coast
Egypt	Alexandria seething with religious violence	The Concord's Old Seat; a heretical "Coptic" order in the Faiyum; Marian hunters
Persia	Sasanians under Kavad I and the Mazdakites	The Mobedān; Hounds of Set across the southern border
Arabia and Yemen	Tribal confederations; Jewish Himyar	Djinn of the deep desert; a Deep One enclave in the Gulf
The Steppe	Hephthalite "White Huns"	Court of Jade Breath

The Mood

Most people in 500 do not believe Rome has fallen. Latin is still the language of Theodoric's chancery. The consuls are still named each year. It is exactly the right moment for a hidden world in which the *old* powers are losing their grip and the *new* ones — Christ, the Outer Ones, whatever comes next — are not yet supreme. Everything is provisional. Everything is up for grabs.

Peoples and Tongues

Characters come from one of the great cultural spheres of the age. Each has a language of learning and a language of the street.

Sphere	Peoples and languages
Romanitas	Italians, Gallo-Romans, Romano-Britons, Africans. Latin; Greek among the learned.
Hellas and the East	Greeks, Anatolians, Syrians, Copts. Greek, Syriac, Coptic, Aramaic.
The Barbaricum	Goths, Franks, Vandals, Saxons, Huns. Gothic, Frankish, Old Saxon; Latin at court.
The Celtic Fringe	Britons, Irish, Picts. Brythonic, Goidelic; Latin among clergy.
Ērānšahr	Persians, Armenians, Sogdians. Middle Persian, Armenian, Sogdian.
The Deserts	Arabs, Berbers, Garamantes, Nubians. Arabic dialects, Berber tongues, Ge'ez.

Faith in the Year 500

- **The Church** is split three ways: Catholic (Rome and Gaul), Chalcedonian Orthodox (Constantinople), and Miaphysite (Egypt and

Syria). The Goths and Vandals are Arian. All of them burn heretics when they can.

- **The old gods** survive in rural shrines, mystery cults, philosophical schools and Germanic war-bands. Their priesthoods are thinning; their pools are draining.
- **Ahura Mazda** is the state faith of Persia, where the Mazdakites preach common property under Kavad's protection.
- **Judaism** thrives from Himyar to Babylon.

Every one of these faiths can point to answered prayers. Which of them is *right* is a question the age is still fighting over.

Chapter 3: What the Learned Teach

The supernatural is not a matter of debate in the year 500. The gods are real. Spirits walk beside the living. The question is never *whether* — only *what kind*, and whose version of it is pointing at you. This is what theurgists, philosophers and the better-read clergy teach.

The Three Spheres

The Mortal Sphere (*Kosmos*)

The world of flesh, iron and stone. Most of the action happens here.

The Veiled Sphere (*Apokryphon*)

The spirit world: the Otherworld, the realm of the Fair Folk, the country beneath the hill, the land of the dead and the dreaming. It lies alongside the mortal world like another country, but its shape is not the same, and it is vast — perhaps infinite. The two Twilight Courts rule its nearer reaches. Theurgists and sorcerers walk in it. Time runs strangely there.

The Veil touches the mortal world where the two share a *resonance*. If a place in the Veil is dark and dreadful, it touches a dark and dreadful place in the Kosmos. Five feet over, it might only be sad — and lead to a cemetery on the other side of the Empire.

The Outer Dark (*Exōthen*)

What lies beyond the edges of the Veil, outside reality. The philosophers call it the Outer Dark; the frightened prefer not to name it. Those who travel there do not come back sane, if they come back. The oldest prohibitions exist to keep it shut.

The Outer Ones

The Concord teaches that certain things press against reality from outside. It refuses them the word *theoi*, gods. They are *Hoi Exō* ("those outside"), *Daimones Akosmoi* ("the un-worlded ones"), or in Persian usage *Drujān*, "the Lies." Scholars know four by name, and do not say the names lightly.

Designation	What is taught
The Throne at the Center	A blind, idiot vortex at the heart of the Outer Dark. Reality is the dream it dœs not know it is having.
The Gate and the Key	All times and places at once. The being one summons to *know*. To know it is to be unmade.
The Crawling Chaos	The one that speaks, walks and plays politics. It has a thousand masks.
The Black Goat of the Woods	A fertility-horror under many masks, worshipped in deep forests and rotting places.

Gods and Worship

Priests work wonders with power their god lends them. A priest is only as strong as her god's favour, and gods can be displeased, distracted or weakened — often without warning. The old gods of Greece and Rome are plainly weaker than they were; the god of the Church is plainly stronger.

Every faith also agrees that devotion costs something. A night's vigil, a festival, a sacrifice: the faithful come away tired in a way sleep alone explains. Priests call it the gift of the self. The rules call it the first Campaign Truth.

How Magic Works

Magic is **the imposition of a name on reality**. To name a thing in its true tongue is to compel it. The recognised traditions are Theurgy, Goeteia, Magia, Hermetica and the priestly art of Hieratica, with the druids and the Hidden Faithful outside the Concord's schools. There is also a language older than the gods, which should never be spoken. See **The Art of Names**.

The **Seven Seals of Solomon** are the Concord's absolute prohibitions. The Concord teaches that they are not laws in a mortal sense but **part of the structure of reality**: to break one weakens the walls between the Sphere and the Dark.

Every tradition agrees that power is not free.
When it seems to cost nothing, be suspicious.

Chapter 4: The Concordat of Hidden Powers

In 287 BC, after a war between the Etruscan vampire-houses of Rome and the wizard-college of Alexandria nearly drowned Italy, a treaty was struck: the **Concordat of Hidden Powers** (*Concordia Potestatum Occultarum*). Long Night calls it the **Pact of the Long Night**, because its drafter was Morrigna.

The Clauses

- **Hospitality.** A host must protect any signatory guest under their roof.
- **Parley.** A truce under the white-and-black banner cannot be broken without forfeiting standing.
- **Duels.** Disputes between signatories may be settled by champion-combat, often by the Courts' Knights.
- **Weregild.** Blood-prices are codified for harm done to non-combatants.
- **Outside-Threat.** All signatories must defend reality against the Outer Dark. The Brotherhood exists to undermine this clause.
- **Mortal Sovereignty.** Hidden powers may *influence* mortal kingdoms but may not openly rule them. Often violated; often punished.

Signatories in 500

- The Concord of the Seven Seals
- The Court of Long Night
- The Court of the Burning Crown
- The House of Lamia
- The Hounds of Set (the **Houndmaster of Carthage** alone)
- The Strigoi of Dacia (**Bessos the Undying** in person; **Anthousa Skoteine** speaks for the elder lineage)
- The Yithian Archive (as Observer)
- The Mobedān of Persia (since about 380)
- **Ambrosius Aurelianus**, Freeholding Lord of Sub-Roman Britain

Known Non-Signatories

- The Brotherhood of the Black Pharaoh (refused; in breach by definition)
- The Esoteric Order of Dagon (signed about 800 BC; lapsed)
- The Court of Jade Breath (will not deal with the West, but is treated as if it had signed)
- The Church (forbidden to treat with "principalities of the air"; individual bishops do, deniably)

The Concordat's clauses have rules weight; see **Oaths, Guest-Right and Parley**.

Chapter 5: The Hidden Powers

What follows is what a well-connected character knows or has heard: names, reputations, offices and folklore. It is not the whole truth about any of them. Where an entry says *it is said*, treat that literally.

The Concord of the Seven Seals

The worldwide council of wizards (*Concordia Septem Sigillorum*). Its members appear in the world as scholars, physicians and court philosophers. It teaches that it was founded in the 3rd century BC by the philosopher-magus **Iamblichus the Elder** out of Alexandria's secret theurgic school. Its spiritual home, the **Old Seat**, lies beneath the ruined Serapeum. Its working library and its business have moved to the **Castrum of Drepanum** in Bithynia.

Office	Holder
Magister Sigillorum	Theognostos of Smyrna, who casts the deciding vote
The Inner Seal	Seven eldest theurgists, among them Damaskios of Damaskos and Markos Drepanios of Thessalonike
Gatekeeper of the Outer Dark	Rashidun of Edessa, who screens those returning from the Veil
The Stylites	The ash-cloaked enforcers, captained by Loukia Theoktiste
The Concord at large	A few hundred recognised magoi worldwide

Robes and Stoles

Apprentices wear undyed wool. Full members wear a **blue** stole; the Inner Seal **purple**; a century of service **red**. A silver braid marks a master of *Pharmakeia* (alchemy), a gold caduceus a master of *Iatreia* (healing), a copper chevron a doctorate from Alexandria, Athens, Edessa or Nisibis. Stylites wear **ash-grey** cloaks woven not to hold blood, and carry iron swords consecrated to cut through enchantment.

Fronts

The **School of Alexandria** (medicine, astronomy), the **Academy of Athens** (philosophy), the **School of Nisibis** (theology and Syriac learning) and the **School of Toulouse**. Each is a real school with real students.

What People Say

The Concord is cautious, bureaucratic and slow to trust — until it moves, and then it moves decisively. Stylites are rumoured to include an elite of blade-bearers whom no one names. Magi forbid themselves open rule: they may advise kings, never be kings. A magus who breaks a Seal is a **paranomos**, and the Concord's verdict is almost always the sword. The young are sometimes spared under the **Sword of Damocles**.

What You Might Need From Them

Identification of threats, authentication of texts and relics, and — rarely — sanction for something their own rules forbid. What they want from you is deniability, speed, and someone to go where their robes can't.

The Four Sanguine Courts

Four different kinds of being share the name "blood-drinker" (*haematopotēs*, *sanguisuga*). They despise being confused with one another. All four have some accommodation with mortal society, and that is exactly why you need to know their terms. Rules for them are in **The Blood-Drinkers**.

The Hounds of Set

Powerful, eccentric nobles of the Vandal court at Carthage and the old towns of Egypt, said to descend from a corrupted cult of Set. They wear flesh-masks — *personae* — over a true form folklore describes with jackal heads and folded wings. Their culture prizes **thirst-discipline**: status is the ability *not* to feed. They keep addicted servants called **Cup-Slaves** (*calicarii*), and half-turned soldiers in bronze jackal masks, the **Jackal-Wardens**. Their master is the **Red Pharaoh**, believed by mortals to be a Vandal client-prince.

Known nobles: **Geilamir the Pale**, *magister officiorum* at Carthage; **Lady Cyria of Sabratha**, who passes as a Berber princess. They are said to be **paralysed by thresholds**: a blessed doorway can stop a duke. The Concord is fighting an undeclared war with them in Sicily, and the **Fellowship of the Lance**, a Roman-Berber militia, hunts them.

The House of Lamia

The old patrician families of Rome, Ravenna and Constantinople — exactly who they appear to be, except that they feed on **emotion**. They own magistracies, ships, brothels, oil presses, theatre troupes and several Senate seats, and broker much of the silk and spice trade. They claim descent from the Libyan queen Lamia of Greek myth. Their court language is Etruscan. They are the most human-passing of the Courts, and they almost never fight openly.

Branch	Feeds on	Said to fear
Velthuri	Lust and intimacy	Those who truly love and are loved; tokens of true love
Malvora	Fear	Genuine courage
Scæva	Despair	Genuine hope

The House is ruled in name by the **Domina Maxima**, who has lain powerless in Rome since a Concord witch, **Markella of Tarentum**, laid a curse on her. In practice her daughter **Larthia Velthuri** rules from the Aventine. Markella's son is **Markos Drepanios** of the Inner Seal, which makes for interesting family dinners.

The Strigoi of Dacia

The walking dead of the Carpathians, who do not pretend to be alive. They were nearly wiped out three centuries ago by a hunting manual, *Peri Strigōn*, written by the physician **Hierokles of Thessalonike**. The survivors are old, paranoid and very cunning. **Bessos the Undying**, Lord of the Carpathian Halls, signed the Concordat in person. **Anthousa Skoteine**, "the Shadowed," lives in Constantinople and is said to work magic like a wizard. A band of Strigoi is a *scourge*.

The Court of Jade Breath

Something from the far east, known mostly by the care people take to avoid it. It deals through Sogdian merchants who carry notes they will not read aloud. Survivors speak of a killing that comes from a distance, with no mark and no touch — a stolen breath. It never signed the Concordat, but everyone treats it as if it had.

The Two Twilight Courts

Two Courts divide the deeper Veil. Each is ruled by three Queens — **Maiden**, **Queen** and **Crone** — turning through one throne like the seasons. Each names a **mortal Knight**, the only one of its people permitted to kill outside the Court; the Knight bears a **Mantle** of borrowed power. There is **no Faerie King**. The **Stone Throne** passes between the Courts at the solstices.

The Fair Folk do not lie. This is not a virtue. They have become extraordinarily good at technical truth, flattering ambiguity, and omissions that lead you where they wanted. A favour accepted without clear terms is a debt without a ceiling.

The Court of Long Night

The Winter Court: cold, precise and merciless. It claims descent from a polar people that fell before the first cities. Its fae are the *Brumales*. Its capital is **Arctistor**, a fortress of black glass in the northern Veil. **Morrigna**, Queen of Hoarfrost and the Slow Knife, drafted the Concordat; she is said to loathe inaccurate folktales about her people. The Maiden is her daughter **Niamh of the Pale Hand**. The Knight is **Edica the Wolf-Marked**, a broken Pannonian. Its sworn include the Cat Sith, the Leannan-Sidhe, Jenna of the Green Teeth, the Redcap and Rawhead.

The Winter Court buys mortal debts, and its debt-collectors are the bargainers in lonely places the Church calls devils. Some say it is also part of the reason worse things have not yet eaten your village. It is weak to **cold iron** — iron worked by mortal smiths.

The Court of the Burning Crown

The Summer Court: warm, beautiful, generous-seeming, and no less precise. It claims the bull-kings of Crete and the green ladies of Etruria among its ancestors. Its fae are the *Aestivales*. Its capital is the **Hall of Beaten Gold**. **Aigle**, Queen of Lions and Olives, is Morrigna's twin; she has never forgiven Markos Drepanios for the death of her daughter **Heliodora** in 497. The Maiden is **Hesperia**. The Knight is **Theodoros Sebennytos**, an Egyptian soldier. It touches mortals through dreams, harvests and Bacchic rites, and it hates the sea-covenant of Sidon with an old, hot hatred.

The Free Folk

Fae of neither Court: satyrs, nymphs, the Erlking's Wild Hunt, Gwynn ap Nudd, the djinn, the kobolds of the mines, the *lares* of every Roman house. Milk at the threshold, bread at the mine-mouth and silver at the crossroads are the terms of small, ancient contracts. Keep them.

The Brotherhood of the Black Pharaoh

The one power that wants nothing you can bargain with. The Brotherhood is said to be a scattered fellowship of scholars, priests and sorcerers who believe the world should **end**, and who work patiently across generations to open a door and let in what comes after. It worships the Crawling Chaos under the mask of **Nephren-Ka**, a pharaoh whose name was struck from the temple lists. It works through respectable men — a learned priest, a rich patron, a scholar with an unusual library. In the Faiyum it is said to pose as a heretical Coptic order. It never signed the Concordat, and every signatory is bound to oppose it.

Signs of Presence

- A respectable man with an inexplicable interest in sealed ruins and the oldest names.
- A ritual site prepared with great care for no purpose that benefits anyone.
- The sudden, quiet interest of the Stylites in a place you thought ordinary.
- Scholars dying or vanishing along a line that points somewhere on a map.

The Esoteric Order of Dagon

The sea-covenant of the Phoenician coast, above all ancient **Sidon**. An order of fishers, navigators and harbour-pilots who serve **Father Dagon** and **Mother Hydra**. Their boats don't sink and their nets don't fail. The older members of these families are known for wide, flat eyes, slick skin, a resistance to cold, and high collars. Coastal towns that host them prosper. Towns that resist have bad years. If people walk into the sea at night in a town that has been lucky for generations, ask when the luck began.

The Yithian Archive

The wandering scholars. There are people who read too fast, sleep too little, tilt their heads at the same angle, and want only your *testimony* of what it felt like to be present at something that mattered. Their embassy is a child: **Eudokia of Antioch**, nine years old, called **the Recorder**. She walks under the Concordat as an Observer, and even Morrigna treats her with deference. People are said to lose months or years to these scholars and come back dreaming of vast windowless libraries. Never make them a binding promise: they measure time in centuries.

The Gnostic Apokryphon

The Hidden Faithful: a network of cells from Alexandria to Edessa to the Faiyum, hunted by the Church for four centuries and still here, barely. Their texts are buried in jars in the sand; their teachers meet in the back rooms of textile shops. One branch is said to have hidden inside the Church's own clergy. Their public teaching runs roughly thus: *the world is not as it appears; the power that demands exclusive worship is not what it claims to be; and the man the Church made a god was a mortal teacher who discovered something extraordinary.* They don't convert. They test, and if you fail, you never hear from them again. Being seen with

one makes you a heretic. Their four workings are in **The Art of Names**.

The Cult of Mormo

Something that wears the face of fertility. Mormo's cells grow inside kinder faiths — of motherhood, harvest and the female divine — and hollow them out, so the rite meant to bless the fields becomes something else while the worshippers think they are doing what their grandmothers did. The Concord files her as a mask of the Black Goat. She feeds on rot, plague and despair, and the fifth century has given her plenty. Her wandering priestesses travel as performers and beggars, hunting the grieving and the desperate. The eve of the vernal equinox is her **Day of Blood**.

Signs of Presence

- Livestock with tumours and strange growths, especially in spring.
- A fertility festival gone subtly *wrong*.
- Wandering performers who stay a little too long.

The Marian Hunters

Widows, consecrated virgins, ascetics and grieving mothers in the blue of the Madonna hunt Mormo's sects, region by region — and their prayers against her are *answered*. They are deadliest in Egypt, but they appear wherever the Church has gone.

The Mobedān

The Zoroastrian magi of Persia, keepers of the fire temples and of *Magia*, the fire-and-word. They acceded to the Concordat around 380. They are old friends of the Winter Court, wary friends of the Concord, and enemies of *the Lie* in all its forms.

Chapter 6: Magi of the Age

Famous names, living and dead, that every magus of the age has heard.

Figure	What is known
Solomon ben David	The First Sealer, who bound the demons of the Levant by ring and seal. The Seven Seals bear his name. His signet ring is said to lie in the Temple Mount rubble.
Iamblichos of Chalkis	Dead since 325. Divided the art into Cantrip, Operation and Theurgy. His *De Mysteriis* is required reading at the Castrum.
Hypatia of Alexandria	The last Magistra of the Old Seat, murdered by a Christian mob in 415. Her ghost is said to walk the Old Seat's empty halls.
Damaskios of Damaskos	42, Inner Seal, head of the Athenian house and the Academy. Brilliant, prickly, fond of wine. Thinks the Magister a bureaucrat and says so.
Bœtius of Ravenna	20, a junior Concord member at Theodoric's court and Damaskios's protégé. Idealistic, politically naive, and in a position to pay for help.
The Master of Tyana	Apollonios, dead 400 years: a wandering wonder-worker claimed by the Concord, the Gnostics and worse. His staff is said to lie in one of his shrines.
Simon of Sebaste	Simon Magus, who tried to buy the Holy Spirit and died, the Church says, in a flying duel with Peter. The Samaritans tell it differently.
Myrddin Emrys	7, a Brythonic boy taken east by Stylites in 497, now the Concord's ward at Drepanum. He speaks in his sleep.
Ambrosius Aurelianus	50, Concord-trained battle-mage and lord of Cær-Gloui, a signatory in his own right. Has not forgiven the Concord for taking Myrddin.
Mug Ruith	The blind Wheel-Druid of Valentia Island, outside every jurisdiction. Answers anyone who pays his toll. The price is never gold.
Bondos the Reformer	A Persian heresiarch two centuries dead, whose teaching the Mazdakites claim. Some say he still lives.
Kartīr of the Seven Heavens	The great high priest of the early Sasanians, who claimed to have ascended through the seven heavens.

Chapter 7: Places of Power

1 Seats of the Concord

1.a The Old Seat, Alexandria

Pillared halls beneath the demolished Serapeum, warded so that "only a being of godhead may pass." Mostly empty now, and said to be haunted.

1.b The Castrum of Drepanum, Bithynia

A Roman coastal fort fronted by a small school. Beneath it, the Concord's library, laboratories, the Hall of the Inner Seal, and the chamber where paranomoi are judged.

1.c The Four Schools

Alexandria, Athens, Nisibis and Toulouse. Real schools, with real students and doors that most students never find.

2 The Veiled Sphere

2.a Arctistor

The Winter Court's fortress of black glass and bone-white pillars. Its gates are said to lie in Iceland, the Carpathians and the high Caucasus.

2.b The Hall of Beaten Gold

The Summer Court's sunlit palace of gold and olive-wood on a mountain that does not exist. Gates in Crete, Etruria and the Lebanon.

2.c The Cottage

Folklore tells of a hut deep in the Veil where two old women spin, one with black thread and one with gold. Those who go looking for it rarely find it. Those who find it wish they hadn't.

3 Places of Rumour

3.a Sarra

A temple-city said to lie buried under the sand of the deep Sahara, and to wake in long cycles.

3.b The Drowned Library, off Sidon

Something older than the Phoenicians lies under the water near Sidon. The sea-covenant guards it.

3.c Karanis, the Faiyum

A sleepy Egyptian town above something that is not sleepy at all.

Chapter 8: Timeline

As the Concord teaches it.

Antiquity

- **c. 1500 BC** — Pharaoh Nephren-Ka rules Egypt. His name is struck from the lists.
- **c. 950 BC** — Solomon binds the demons of the Levant by ring and seal.
- **287 BC** — The Concordat of Hidden Powers is sealed after a war between the vampire-houses of Rome and the wizards of Alexandria.
- **c. 250 BC** — Iamblichus the Elder founds the Concord at Alexandria.
- **47 BC** — The Library of Alexandria burns the first time.
- **c. 30–33** — The ministry and death of Jesus of Nazareth.
- **c. 96** — Death of Apollonios of Tyana.

The Imperial Era

- **c. 300** — Hierokles' *Peri Strigōn* all but ends the Strigoi.
- **325** — Death of Iamblichos of Chalkis.
- **c. 380** — The Mobedān accede to the Concordat.
- **391** — The Serapeum is destroyed; the Old Seat is sealed.
- **415** — Hypatia is murdered in Alexandria.
- **431** — The Council of Ephesus proclaims Mary *Theotokos*, Mother of God.

Living Memory

- **476** — The last Western emperor is deposed.
- **488** — Theodoric invades Italy.
- **493** — Theodoric kills Odoacer.
- **496** — Clovis is baptised.
- **497** — Heliodora, Maiden of the Summer Court, dies at Arctistor; Markos Drepanios is blamed. The Stylites take the boy Myrddin from Dyfed.
- **498** — Kavad is restored to the Persian throne and embraces the Mazdakites.
- **500** — **Play begins.**

Part 3
Rules of the Hidden World

Chapter 1: Campaign Truths

Every 2d12 setting starts with **Campaign Truths**: facts that are always true and that the rules lean on. Aetas Obscura has five.

1 · Devotion Has a Cost
Worship takes something from those who take part. When a character joins a real rite — a Mass, a sacrifice, a festival, a sincere prayer at an altar — they lose **1 Pneuma**, which returns at their next rest. Belief changes nothing; attendance does. See **Worship and Hieratica**.

2 · Names Have Power
Magic is the imposition of a name on reality. A **true name** learned through Discover, a text or a bargain counts as a **power tag** on every roll against its bearer, and some workings cannot be attempted without one.

3 · The Seals Are Walls
The Seven Seals are part of reality's architecture. Breaking one has a cost whether or not anyone sees. The GM keeps track of how thin the walls have grown. See **The Seven Seals**.

4 · Thresholds and Oaths Hold
A blessed threshold, a guest-right, a parley banner and a sworn oath are *forces*, not customs. The hidden world obeys them, and breaking them is a wound. See **Oaths, Guest-Right and Parley**.

5 · The Dark Is Patient
Exposure to the Outer Dark leaves *nemesion*, a taint that does not heal with rest. The Outer Ones are unwinnable on their own terms. Human-scale victories still count. See **Dread and Nemesion**.

Setting Dials

Choose one setting for each dial at Session Zero.

Dial	Settings
Visibility	*Open* (wizards in the Senate, færie embassies at weddings — the default) · *Veiled* (rumours only) · *Buried* (the hidden world is truly hidden)
Horror	*Pulp* (Dread costs reduced by 1 tier) · *Dark* (default) · *Bleak* (nemesion cannot be cleansed below tier 1)
The Church	*Divided* (default) · *Militant* (heresy accusations are a Wœ spend at 1 instead of 2) · *Tolerant*

Chapter 2: Skills of the Age

The core skill list is renamed for the year 500. Ratings, the pyramid and default pools are unchanged.

Sōma	**Akmē**	**Psychē**	**Pneuma**
Athletics	Shoot	Notice	Will
Brawl	Stealth	Investigate	Persuade
Fight	**Ride**	**Letters**	Intimidate
Endure	Craft	**Mechanica**	Empathy
Wayfaring		Medicine	**Mysteria**
		Deceive	

Core	**Becomes**	**Covers**
Survival	**Wayfaring**	Roads, deserts, forests, weather, foraging, tracking, the sea by coast-light
Drive/Pilot	**Ride**	Horses, mules, camels, chariots, carts, and small boats
Lore	**Letters**	Law, history, theology, philosophy, languages, heraldry, the Classics, tactics
Tech	**Mechanica**	Siegecraft, locks, aqueducts, Hero's automata, Greek fire, astrolabes
Arcana	**Mysteria**	Magic of every tradition, ritual, spirits, the Veil, and priestly rites

Notes

- **Letters** is the tactics skill for **Battle** conflicts, as Lore is in the core.
- **Mysteria** is the anchor for the **Adept**. A priest of Hieratica uses Mysteria too; the rite is the same skill whether the hand behind it is a god or the magus himself.
- **Mechanica** is rare. In the year 500, a character with Mechanica +3 is a famous engineer.
- **Literacy** is not a skill. Characters of the **Lettered** and **Honoured** stations read; others read only if they have Letters +1 or more.

Chapter 3: Characters of the Age

Make characters with the core rules: a **Descriptor**, a **Playbook** and a **Focus**. This chapter adds an **Origin** (culture and station) and an optional **Allegiance**, and shows how the core options look in the year 500.

> I am a *Haunted Savant* who *Remembers What Was Forgotten* — a Syriac-speaking freedman of Edessa, indebted to the Concord.

Origin

Choose a **cultural sphere** (see **The World in 500 AD**) and a **station**. Then write one **Origin tag** that combines them: *Alexandrian physician's daughter*, *Gothic spear-oath man*, *runaway colonus from the Lucanian estates*.

- The Origin tag **replaces one of the two tags your Playbook gives**. Your tag count doesn't change.
- You speak your sphere's street language and any languages your station gives.
- Your station gives a **trait** and a **burden**. The burden works like a weakness tag the GM can compel.

Stations

Roman law divides people into *honestiores*, the honoured, and *humiliores*, the humble. The humble can be beaten, tortured for testimony and sent to the mines. Barbarian and Persian law draw the same line in other words.

Outcast

Beggar, bandit, heretic, runaway, actor, gravedigger.

- *Languages:* the street tongue only.
- **Trait — Beneath Notice.** Once per scene in a crowd, Create the Truth *Nobody Looks at Beggars* without paying for it.
- **Burden — Without Law.** No court will hear you. Persuading anyone in authority is one step harder.

Servile

Slave, freedman, *colonus* bound to an estate, household servant.

- *Languages:* your own, and your master's.
- **Trait — Below Stairs.** Once per session, take a free bonus die on a roll to learn something from servants, slaves or a household.
- **Burden — A Claim on You.** Someone — a master, a patron, an estate — has a legal claim on you, and may press it.

Common

Craftsman, soldier, sailor, farmer, shopkeeper, guard.

- *Languages:* your own, and one trade tongue.
- **Trait — Common Cause.** Among working people, Persuade starts at Standard even when a stranger would face Hard. Once per session, their help gives the party 1 Momentum.
- **Burden — Humilior.** The law may beat or torture you. In a dispute with your betters, you lose.

Lettered

Merchant, scribe, notary, clergy, town councillor (*curialis*), physician.

- *Languages:* your own, Latin or Greek, and one more. You read and write.
- **Trait — Letters of Introduction.** Once per session, produce a document or a name that gets you through a door: Create the Truth *Expected and Admitted* for the scene.
- **Burden — Obligations.** Taxes, tithes, guild dues or a bishop's orders follow you everywhere.

Honoured

Senator, Gothic or Frankish noble, Persian *āzād*, bishop of a great see.

- *Languages:* your own, Latin or Greek, and two more. You read and write.
- **Trait — Dignitas.** You cannot lawfully be tortured. Once per session, demand an audience with anyone short of a king and receive it. A household retinue counts as gear that takes no Load.
- **Burden — Honour and Rivals.** Insults must be answered. Scandal follows you, and your enemies sit at court.

Allegiance (optional)

Name one faction your character is tied to, and how.

Tie	What it means
Sworn	A member: a Concord apprentice, a Court's servant, a Stylite, an initiate. You get a **Contact** in the faction and access to its places.
Indebted	You owe it. You get one favour now, recorded as a Debt (see **The Veiled Sphere**).
Hunted	It wants you. Start with a 4-clock *They Close In* the GM ticks with Wœ.

The Call. Once per session, the GM may have your faction call on you. Answer at real cost and gain **1 Tychē**. Refuse and the tie frays: Sworn becomes Indebted, Indebted becomes Hunted.

Playbooks of the Age

Core playbook	In the year 500
Bellator	Legionary veteran, *bucellarius*, Gothic warrior, gladiator, Fellowship of the Lance hunter, Stylite, a Court's Knight
Furcifer	Tomb robber, spy of the *agentes in rebus*, cutpurse, assassin, smuggler, Lamia-house thief
Savant	Philosopher, physician of Alexandria, Concord scholar, astrologer, lawyer, engineer, Mobedān scribe
Interlocutor	Rhetor, envoy, merchant of the Silk Road, courtier, bishop's secretary, conman
Explorator	Hunter, horse-archer, sailor, caravan guide, Saxon raider, desert scout
Adept	Magus of a tradition: theurge, goēs, Mobed, Hermeticist, druí, priest of Hieratica, Gnostic initiate

Renamed Equipment

Use the **Fantasy** options wherever the core lists genres. The Adept's *conduit* is a staff, wand or ring of Solomon's pattern; the *faith made solid* talisman is a phylactery, an Isis-knot or a relic fragment.

Descriptors and Focuses That Fit

All core Descriptors work. Some Focuses read differently in the year 500.

Focus	Suits
Hunts the Things in the Dark ◈	Stylites, Fellowship hunters, Marian widows
Walks Between Worlds ◈	Fæ-touched, Veil-wanderers, the Recorder's escorts
Made a Bargain With Something Old ◈	Knights, Lamia thralls, anyone with a Debt
Is More Than Human ◈	fæ-blooded changelings, half-turned Jackal-Wardens, sea-covenant children before the change
Remembers What Was Forgotten	Concord scholars, Gnostic couriers
Carries the Weight of a Crown	Gothic and Frankish nobles, Ambrosius's captains
Was Born Behind the Wheel	Rename it *Was Born in the Saddle*: horse-archers, charioteers of the Hippodrome
Knows Everyone Worth Knowing	Senators, bishops' secretaries, Lamia clients

Setting Gear

These gear tags join the core lists.

Item	Load	Tag and effect
Cold-iron blade	1	*cold iron*. Harms Long Night fæ normally even when they are Hard to Kill; counts as a killing method against some.
Phylactery or amulet	0	*warded*. Once per session, reduce one supernatural harm by +1 tier when you Resist.
Blessed salt, holy water	0	*consecrated (patron)*. Draw a threshold line; Hounds and Strigoi must pay 1 Wœ to cross it.
Lead curse tablet	0	*defixio*. A Gœteia focus: +1 to curse workings against a named target.
Papyrus grimoire	1	*text of power*. Lets a Scholar use Letters for workings (see **The Art of Names**).

Item	Load	Tag and effect
Kyphi and censer	1	*the fragrant smoke*. +1 segment on the first roll of any Rite.
Relic fragment	0	*steeped in worship*. Strigoi weakness; may count as a killing method; a Hieratica priest gains +1 Favour once.
Stylite ash-cloak	0	*dœs not hold blood*. Armour 0; +1 to Intimidate against those who know what it means.
Seal-ring	0	*Solomon's pattern*. +1 Power on workings that bind or banish.

Chapter 4: The Art of Names

To name a thing in its true tongue is to compel it. Every magus of the age — theurge, goēs, Mobed or druí — works by that law. What differs is the tongue, the price, and which Seal it puts at risk.

This chapter builds on the **Adept** playbook. The Adept's Domain, scope Difficulties, working cost, backlash and Ritual ability all apply as written. A tradition adds **where the power comes from**, **what it is good at**, and **what it costs**.

Who Works Magic

- **Adepts** are magi. Choose a **tradition** and a **path** when you take the playbook. Your Domain must be one your tradition teaches.
- **Anyone else** can be a **Dabbler** (see Paths), or perform a **Rite** they have been taught or have read.
- **Priests** of any playbook can work **Hieratica** if they hold Favour with a patron (see **Worship and Hieratica**).

The Three Tiers

Iamblichos divided the art into three tiers. They match the core scopes.

Tier	Scope	In play
Cantrip	Minor, personal (Easy 12)	Light a lamp, warm water, sense a lie in a room. Often no roll.
Operation	Significant to Spectacular (15–21)	A single working: a roll of Mysteria, 1 Pneuma.
Theurgy	World-shaking (Heroic 24)	Always a **Rite** run as a progress clock.

Paths

How you learned shapes how you work.

Initiate

Taught by a master in a lineage. The default for Adepts.

- You may learn the tradition's Rites from your teacher without a text.
- Your lineage protects you: once per session, reduce a backlash status by 2 tiers.
- You have a master. The master has expectations.

Scholar

Self-taught from texts: the Greek Magical Papyri, a Hermetic codex, a stolen Concord notebook.

- With a *text of power* in hand, you may roll **Letters** instead of Mysteria for workings and Rites.
- You can learn a second Domain from a text instead of taking ⋆ **Second Domain** — but only for workings done with that text in hand.
- No one taught you the safeguards. Your backlash statuses are **+1 tier**.

Dabbler

Any non-Adept with a charm, a curse-tablet, a grandmother's song.

- Write a narrow **Charm** tag: *the evil eye*, *knot-magic for fair winds*, *a love-spell from the papyri*.
- You can attempt Cantrips and Significant workings within the Charm. Roll Mysteria (or Letters with a text).
- Each working costs **2 Pneuma**, and **any** doubles cause backlash, success or not.
- You can perform Rites you are taught (see Rites).

The Traditions

Each entry gives the tradition's **Domains**, its **Strength**, its **Price**, and the **Seals it endangers**.

Theurgy

The Concord's tradition · Neoplatonic ascent

Domains: light, warding, the soul and its ascent, the spheres and stars, healing, divination, banishing.

Strength — The Safe Way. Theurgy is slow, ceremonial and safe. When you take backlash from a Theurgy working, reduce it by 1 tier.

Price — Ceremony. An Operation needs a minute of invocation. In a scripted conflict, a Theurgy working can't be your first action in an exchange.

Seals at risk: rarely any. That is the point.

Goeteia

Name-binding sorcery · the Greek Magical Papyri

Domains: binding, curses, compulsion, the dead and the chthonic, love and hate, summoning daimones.

Strength — The Name Is the Leash. With a true name, Goeteia workings against its bearer get **+1 Power**.

Price — Chthonic Powers. Goeteia borrows from below. Whenever you use Effort on a Goeteia working, the GM gains **1 Woe**.

Seals at risk: III (the Mind), IV (Bondage), V (the Border). Goeteia breaks Seals easily.

Magia

The fire-and-word of the Mobedān

Domains: fire, truth and the Lie, purity and purification, exposure of the dead, driving out *daēvas* and *drujān*.

Strength — Against the Lie. Magia workings against Outer-touched beings, false gods in masquerade, or anyone who has just lied get **+1 Power**.

Price — Purity. After touching a corpse, spilled blood or the Outer taint, you cannot work Magia until you spend a scene purifying yourself with fire, water and prayer.

Seals at risk: rarely. Magia is distinct from the Concord but respected by it.

Hermetica

The science of correspondences

Domains: alchemy (*pharmakeia*), astrology, correspondences and sympathy, transmutation, automata, talismans.

Strength — Preparations. In downtime, store one working in a potion, talisman or star-chart. Make the roll then; release it later as a free action with no further roll. You may hold as many as your Mysteria rating.

Price — Few Survive. Anyone literate can dabble. Hermetic backlash is **+1 tier**, and a Scholar's adds another.

Seals at risk: II (Shaping), VI (the River).

Druidry and the Northern Arts

The druí, the seiðkona, the galdr-singer

Domains: weather, beasts, shapeshifting by spirit-help, prophecy, battle-fury, the dead, the land.

Strength — Spirit Allies. You may work through a spirit of the place. Once per scene, a working done with the help of a local spirit costs **0 Pneuma**.

Price — Geis. Write a *geis* weakness tag (never eat the flesh of a hound; never refuse a guest). Break it and you cannot work magic until you atone, and the GM gains 2 Woe.

Seals at risk: II (Shaping), V (the Border).

In the year 500, druidic and Saxon magic are, in practice, the same art in different tongues. Christian Britons call both devilry.

Gnostic Praxis

The Hidden Faithful's working · the Apokryphon

Domains: only four, and they are fixed.

- **Anabasis** — the ascent through the archons, naming and refusing each. The most dangerous working: a failed Anabasis Rite kills the initiate in their sleep.
- **Lytrosis** — liberation. Frees a bound or enchanted soul: clears *enthralled* and Lamia thrall-bonds, and weakens Brotherhood bindings.
- **Apokalypsis** — unveiling. Reveals a god in masquerade, a Lamia feeding, a magister mid-rite. Cheap, and easy to detect.
- **Sigesis** — silencing. Hides you from the notice of gods for hours or weeks. Painful.

Strength — Praxis, Not Patron. Gnostic workings never draw on a god. They can't be detected by Hieratica, and are immune to the patron effects in **Worship and Hieratica**.

Price — No Sword. The Apokryphon has no combat magic. Attack effects from Gnostic workings are one step harder. You must learn Sigesis first.

Seals at risk: none — but a church that burns heretics.

The Black Speech

The language of the Outer Ones · never chosen

No one takes the Black Speech as a tradition. It is learned by accident and kept by temptation.

Once you know even a syllable, you may **speak it into any working**: gain **+2 Power**, and take *nemesion-1* that cannot be Resisted. Speaking it in a Rite thins the walls (see **Breaking a Seal**).

Seal broken: VII (the Outer Dark), every time.

Reaching Beyond Your Domain

You may attempt a working outside your Do-

main if it fits your tradition. It is **one step harder**, costs **2 Pneuma**, and **any** doubles cause backlash.

Rites

A Rite is magic run as a **progress clock**: 6 segments for Hard, 8 for Formidable, 12 for Heroic. Adepts with the **Ritual** ability can run any working as a Rite. Anyone else can perform a specific Rite they have been taught or have read.

- **Each roll** takes an hour, a night, or a day, as the Rite demands. Success fills segments equal to Power. Failure fills none and advances a danger clock the GM names.
- **Untrained:** a character without the Ritual ability adds **+4 segments** to the clock, and any doubles cause backlash.
- **Assistants:** each trained assistant can Help (core rules). Untrained assistants just hold the candles — but they still pay the cost of devotion.
- **Place:** in a *Thin Place* or on ground holy to the power invoked, remove 2 segments.
- **Results** can create Site or Region Truths, as the core Ritual ability allows.

Requirements

Every Rite names its **requirements**: a time (dawn, a new moon, the solstice), a place, materials, and an **offering**. Missing one makes the Rite one step harder or impossible, as the GM rules.

Offerings and Sacrifice

Offering	Effect
Incense, wine, bread	The ordinary price. No bonus.
Your own blood	Lose 2 Sōma. +1 bonus die on one Rite roll.
An animal	+1 segment on every successful roll. The GM gains 1 Wœ.
A willing human life	+3 segments at once. Breaks the **First Seal**. Every participant takes *nemesion-1*.
An unwilling human life	+4 segments at once. Breaks the **First** and **Fourth Seals**. Every participant takes *nemesion-2*. The GM gains 3 Wœ.

Backlash

On backlash the GM chooses a fitting status — *burned-2*, *drained-2*, *hollow-2* — or rolls on this table.

d12	Backlash
1	**The lamps gutter.** Every flame, water-clock and fine mechanism nearby fails for the scene.
2	**Ink runs.** Your text of power is damaged: *blotted* until mended.
3	**Drained.** Lose 2 more Pneuma.
4	**Nosebleed.** *Bleeding-2* (Sōma).
5	**Wrong target.** The effect lands on the nearest wrong person.
6	**Echo.** The working repeats at the worst moment later in the session.
7	**Witnessed.** Something in the Veil saw. The GM gains 2 Wœ.
8	**The mark.** A visible sign — frost on the skin, a smell of myrrh — for a day.
9	**Voices.** *Shaken-2* (Pneuma).
10	**Lost time.** An hour passes that you don't remember.
11	**A door ajar.** The walls between Sphere and Dark grow a little thinner.
12	**Something answers.** A spirit, a fæ or worse takes an interest. Name it.

Broken Clocks

Magi "disrupt fine craftsmanship over time": oil lamps gutter, water-clocks stop, ink runs. A magus's household is full of broken clocks and candles. Others notice.

Chapter 5: The Seven Seals

The Concord teaches that reality is a sealed vessel and magi are its glaziers. Every great violation weakens the glass.

Seal	Prohibition and examples
I · Of Slaying	Thou shalt not kill a man by the art. A killing working; a human sacrifice.
II · Of Shaping	Thou shalt not unmake the shape a thing was born in. Turning a man into a beast; flesh-crafting.
III · Of the Mind	Thou shalt not enter the mind of another and take what is not given. Mind-reading against the will; memory theft.
IV · Of Bondage	Thou shalt not bind the will of another to thy own. Compulsion; thralldom; love-spells.
V · Of the Border	Thou shalt not call back the dead, nor reach across the river. Necromancy; raising shades.
VI · Of the River	Thou shalt not swim against the river of time. Changing what has happened; prophecy that alters its own end.
VII · Of the Outer Dark	Thou shalt not seek what lies beyond the Outer Gates, nor open them, nor call through them. The Black Speech; summoning an Outer thing.

Breaking a Seal

When a character breaks a Seal — by working, Rite or the Black Speech — four things happen, whether or not anyone sees:

1. The GM gains **2 Woe**.
2. The walls between Sphere and Dark grow thinner (the Seventh Seal: much thinner).
3. The character takes *nemesion-1* (the Seventh Seal: *nemesion-2*).
4. If a Concord magus is within a day's ride, or the working is divined, the party's **Stylites** clock ticks.

Spirits, gods and the Courts are not bound by the Seals. Mortal magi are.

Thinning Walls

The GM keeps a secret measure of how thin the walls between Sphere and Dark have grown where you play. You will see the signs: sick animals, shared dreams, Thin Places where none were. Great Rites and Solomonic relics can seal them again.

The Stylites Clock

When the party's magic draws Concord attention, tick a 6-clock *The Stylites Come*. At 6, they arrive with a warrant. A magus caught breaking a Seal is a **paranomos** and goes to trial. The verdict is almost always death by the sword.

The Sword of Damocles

A first-time offender — especially a young one — may be placed under the **Sword of Damocles**: probation under a sponsoring master. While under the Sword:

- you have access to Concord libraries and help, through your sponsor;
- your sponsor may call on you at any time (an Allegiance Call you cannot refuse);
- **any** further Seal violation is death, and your sponsor must carry it out.

The Sword is the classic young-wizard hook. Start an Adept under it if the player agrees.

Chapter 6: Worship and Hieratica

Belief is irrelevant. A cynical priest in good standing with a strong god can work wonders that a sincere outsider cannot. Hieratica is *borrowed* power, lent by a patron to those who serve it.

Patrons and Their Pools

Every patron has a **pool state** that reflects how strong it is at present. The GM knows each patron's state; priests learn it from how their prayers are answered.

State	Effect on Hieratica
Starving	Workings one step harder. Favour refreshes by 1 per session at most. The patron is desperate and will ask terrible things.
Waning	Workings normal. Favour refreshes by 1 per session.
Steady	Workings normal. Favour refreshes to 3 each session.
Waxing	+1 Power on workings. Favour refreshes to 3 each session.
Bloated	+1 Power on workings and Favour refreshes to 5 — but on any doubles, **no one answers**: the working fails and the Favour is spent.

Favour

A priest tracks **Favour** with one patron, from 0 to 5. A starting priest-character has **2**.

- **Spend 1 Favour** to power a Hieratica working instead of paying Pneuma. The patron's state applies.
- **Gain Favour** by serving: a significant service (+1), a great festival or a new congregation (+2), recovering a relic (+1).
- **Lose Favour** by offending the patron, serving a rival, or failing a duty it set.
- **At 0 Favour**, you can still pray. Nothing answers.

Hieratica workings use **Mysteria** and the patron's portfolio as the Domain. Priests who aren't Adepts use the Dabbler limits but pay with Favour.

The Cost of Devotion

The first Campaign Truth says joining a rite costs 1 Pneuma. Remember it when you go to worship to keep a cover and need that Pneuma tonight. A great festival can cost everyone inside 2.

Relics and Consecration

An object steeped in long devotion to a patron is *consecrated (patron)*. Any god's consecrated object troubles Strigoi and Hounds, because each has been soaked in worship they cannot abide. A Mithraic token works as well as a cross.

Chapter 7: Dread and Nemesion

The hidden world wounds the mind in two ways. **Dread** is what horror does to you now. **Nemesion** is what the Outer Dark leaves behind.

Dread

When a character meets something the mind was not made for, the GM names an incoming status and its tier. Resist it with the core rules.

- **Fear and revulsion** — a risen corpse, a Hound's true face, a sacrifice — inflict *shaken*. Resist with **Pneuma**.
- **Forbidden knowledge** — a page of the Drowned Library, a geometry that should not close — inflicts *unmoored*. Resist with **Psychē**.

Exposure	Tier	Examples
Unsettling	1	A fresh corpse in a sacred place; a Lamia's eyes in lamplight
Horrifying	2	A Hound unmasked; a Strigoi rising; a Reborn goat-thing
Appalling	3	A Deep One hybrid mid-change; a human sacrifice; a page of Black Speech
Mind-breaking	4	A Shoggoth-Born; a god's true shape; a Yithian mind-swap remembered
Beyond	5	The land beyond the Outer Gates; a Seal broken before your eyes
Outer	6	An Outer One manifest. Resisting can't reduce this below tier 3.

Familiar Horrors

Once you have Resisted a particular horror — *Hounds*, *the risen dead*, *Deep Ones* — the same kind costs **1 tier less** next time. Familiarity is its own kind of damage. Note it as a tag: *seen Hounds unmasked*.

Madness

At tier 6, *shaken* or *unmoored* Takes you Out as the core rules describe, and the Scar it brings is a **Madness**. Roll or choose.

d12	Madness
1	**Fugue.** You wake far away, days later.
2	**Hysteria.** Laughter or weeping you cannot stop when the horror returns.
3	**Phobia.** Of the thing, or something near it: water, mirrors, goats.
4	**Paranoia.** One ally is lying. You're sure.
5	**Mania.** You must *understand*. You keep the page.
6	**Catatonia.** When it returns, you freeze for a volley.
7	**Voices.** Someone speaks only to you. Sometimes usefully.
8	**Obsession.** A single goal now outranks your Belief.
9	**Compulsive rite.** Salt lines, counted prayers, washing.
10	**Amnesia.** A day, a name, a face — gone.
11	**Watched.** You feel eyes from the Veil, always.
12	**Revelation.** You learned something true. Gain one true name and *nemesion-1*.

Each Madness becomes a **weakness tag**. It can be rewritten into a power tag with Advancement, as the core allows.

Nemesion

Nemesion is the Outer taint. It is a lasting harmful status, tiers 1–6.

- It **does not recover with rest**. It stacks normally.
- It cannot be Resisted when you choose it (the Black Speech, a Mormo rite, a Brotherhood pact).
- It hinders nothing directly — at first.

Sources

Breaking a Seal; speaking the Black Speech; taking part in a sacrifice; feeding an Outer thing; walking beyond the Outer Gates; long contact with the Outer-touched.

What It Does

Tier	Effect
1	Dreams of a starless sky. Nothing visible.
2	A **mark**: an ache in old wounds, a smell of wet stone, eyes that catch the light. Write it as a weakness tag.

Tier	Effect
3	Animals shun you. The Gatekeeper's tests and Magia's fire reveal you.
4	Outer things know you. The GM may spend 2 Wœ to have the Dark act *through* you for one action.
5	The change begins: the gills, the horns, the sores, the hunger. You are Hard to Kill — and hunted.
6	**Lost.** The character belongs to the Dark and becomes an NPC.

The Temptation

At *nemesion-2* or more, you may **lean on the Dark** for any working or Rite roll: gain +1 Power and +1 tier of nemesion. The Brotherhood recruits with exactly this.

Cleansing

Nemesion is removed only by:

- a **Lytrosis** working (Gnostic) or a **Magia** purification by fire, each removing 1 tier per successful working, at a Difficulty of 12 + 3 per tier;
- a great Rite at a holy place (2 tiers);
- a bargain with the Court of Long Night, which is said to know the Dark better than anyone (any number of tiers, at a price).

Chapter 8: The Veiled Sphere

Crossing Over

There are three ways in:

- **A gate** — a known door: Arctistor's gates in Iceland, the Carpathians and the Caucasus; the Hall of Beaten Gold's in Crete, Etruria and the Lebanon; a hidden door in each Concord school. No roll, if you have the key or the right.
- **A Thin Place** — where the Spheres share a resonance. A Mysteria roll at Standard (Hard without the Truth *Thin Place*).
- **A working** — opening the Veil yourself is a Dramatic working (Hard 18) for an Adept whose Domain touches spirits, travel or the Veil.

Travelling by Resonance

The Veil is not mapped by distance but by **feeling**. To reach a place, describe what it *feels* like and roll **Mysteria** or **Empathy**. Success brings you to a door that touches your goal. Failure brings you somewhere that feels the same: the sad place you meant, five feet over, leads to a cemetery on the other side of the Empire.

Time Runs Strangely

When the party returns to the Kosmos, the GM rolls 1d12, or spends Woe to choose.

d12	Time in the Kosmos
1	You return *before* you left. Avoid yourself.
2–4	The same hour.
5–7	A day for every hour.
8–9	A week has passed.
10	A season.
11	A year and a day.
12	Seven years. Your name is on a tomb.

Spend **1 Momentum** to shift the result one row toward 2–4. The GM may spend **2 Woe** to shift it one row down.

Debts

The hidden world runs on favours owed. When a fae, a god or a Court grants you something, record a **Debt**: the creditor, and a weight from 1 to 3.

Weight	Typical favour
1	Directions, a meal, a night's safety, a small truth
2	A healing, a passage through the Veil, a lie told on your behalf
3	A life saved, a curse broken, a true name

- **Calling a Debt.** The creditor names a task. Do it and the Debt is cleared. Refuse and take *forsworn-X* (Pneuma), where X is twice the weight — and the creditor may do as it likes with you under the Concordat.
- **Debts are property.** They can be sold, traded and bought. Morrigna buys them from lesser fae to bring promising mortals under her hand.
- **Hidden Debts.** Eating faerie food, accepting a gift, or entering the Cottage may create a Debt you did not know you took. The GM records it.

Knights and Mantles

A character may become a Court's **Knight**. The Mantle is a gift of borrowed power:

- one **power tag** fitting the Court (*winter's edge*, *summer's wrath*);
- the right to **kill** where the Queen cannot;
- once per session, one Court gift: **Glamour** (Create a Truth of illusion), **Winter's Edge** or **Summer's Wrath** (+1 Power on one attack), or **Step Sideways** (into the Veil);
- and a permanent weight-3 Debt the Queen may call once per session.

When the Knight dies, the Mantle goes home. Those who try to steal it in between are the Knight's real enemies.

Thresholds and Iron

- A **home's threshold** is a ward. Fae, Hounds and Strigoi need to be invited, or must pay **2 Woe** to cross, and lose their Specials while inside unless invited. Lamiae cross freely but lose their Hunger-powers inside.

- **Cold iron** — iron worked by mortal smiths — is a weakness of the Court of Long Night. A cold-iron weapon is a killing method against its fae, and binds them where it is driven into the ground.
- The Burning Crown's weakness varies by sidhe. Make it something found: a midwinter ash, a frozen lake, a word.

The Free Folk at Home

A household can keep Free Folk — *lares*, kobolds, sprites — for regular offerings of milk, honeyed barley-bread and silver. Treat the household as a **Bound Servant** (core Adept ability) that any character can keep, but only in that home. Miss three offerings and it turns.

Chapter 9: The Blood-Drinkers

Four species, one name, no love lost. What follows is what hunters know of each.

Common Rules

- **Hard to Kill.** Physical harm stops at tier 5 unless a **killing method** is used. At tier 5 the blood-drinker is broken (–2 on physical rolls).
- **Feeding** restores the blood-drinker: 1 tier of physical harm per feed.
- **The Masquerade.** All four Courts pass as human (except the Strigoi, who do not try). Unveiling one is a Discover at Hard, or automatic with **Apokalypsis**.

Enthralled

Enthralled is a Pneuma status inflicted by feeding or by saliva. While enthralled, acting against the master is one step harder per two tiers. At tier 6 you are a thrall: Taken Out, and an NPC until freed. **Lytrosis** and *Vinculum Fractum* clear it.

The Hounds of Set

- **Feed on:** blood. Their **saliva** is a narcotic: a bite inflicts *enthralled-2* alongside harm. Cup-Slaves are tier 4 or more.
- **Thirst-discipline.** A Hound may refuse to feed when offered: compelling its hunger (1 Tychē) makes it lose face before its juniors.
- **Thresholds paralyse them.** A blessed doorway stops a duke.
- **Killing methods:** beheading; fire; a relic-blade; sunlight for the young.
- **True face** is a Horrifying exposure.

The House of Lamia

- **Feed on:** emotion, by Branch. Feeding inflicts *hollowed* (Pneuma); sustained feeding kills. Velthuri feeding also inflicts *enthralled*.
- **Branch weaknesses** (see the faction entry) are real: a Velthuri cannot touch one truly loved and loving; a Malvora is harmed by courage (+1 tier to any harm from a character who just Resisted fear); a Scaeva sickens before hope.
- **Thresholds** don't stop them, but inside a home they lose their Hunger-powers.
- **Killing methods:** any lethal means once unveiled — they are the most mortal of the Courts.

The Strigoi of Dacia

- **Feed on:** blood, with the strength of ten men.
- **Weaknesses:** sunlight (deadly to the young, weakening to the old); garlic; any consecrated object; they **cannot cross thresholds** uninvited; they must sleep in native earth.
- **Killing methods:** stake, behead and burn — all three, as *Peri Strigōn* teaches.
- **Servants:** thralls and darkhounds.

The Court of Jade

Breath

- **Feed on:** breath, at the width of a courtyard. A feeding inflicts *breathless* (Sōma) at range, no touch needed.
- **Mien.** An insult is a Debt of weight 3, and they always call it.
- **Killing methods:** unknown in the West. Let the players earn one.

Chapter 10: Oaths, Guest-Right and Parley

The Concordat's clauses are not etiquette. In play they are Truths with teeth.

Clause	At the table
Hospitality	Create the Truth *Under My Roof*. A host must protect any signatory guest; a guest must not harm the host.
Parley	Raise the white-and-black banner: Create the Truth *Banner of Parley*. No violence until it is lowered.
Duel	Signatories may settle a dispute by champion. Run a Fight between champions; the result binds both sides as an agreed outcome.
Weregild	Harm to non-combatants carries a price: a Debt of weight 1–3 owed to the injured party's faction.
Outside-Threat	Any signatory may demand any other's help against the Outer Dark. Refusing makes the refuser *forsworn*.
Mortal Sovereignty	Ruling openly is a breach. The other signatories may act against the breaker without Weregild.

Forsworn

Breaking guest-right, parley or a sworn oath inflicts *forsworn-3* (Pneuma), and the oath-breaker's faction loses standing. While forsworn:

- other signatories owe you nothing under the Concordat;
- Fae and Courts may compel you once per scene as if they held your Debt;
- the status clears only when Weregild is paid, or a Queen forgives it.

Swearing an Oath

When a character swears a true oath — by a Seal, a Court, or a patron — write it as a power tag for as long as they keep it. Breaking it costs the tag, inflicts *forsworn-3*, and gives the GM 2 Woe.

Chapter 11: Conflicts of the Age

Scripted conflicts work as in the core rules. This setting renames some core types, removes **Hack / Netwar**, and adds five of its own.

Type	Disp.	Attack	Defend	Feint	Maneuver
Fight	Fight / Brawl	Fight / Brawl / Shoot	Athletics / Endure	Deceive	Notice / Stealth
Chase	Athletics / Ride	Athletics / Ride	Athletics / Ride	Stealth	Notice / Wayfaring
Argument	Persuade	Persuade	Will	Deceive	Empathy
Negotiation	Persuade	Persuade	Empathy	Deceive	Investigate
Infiltration	Stealth	Stealth / Mechanica	Deceive	Craft	Investigate
Battle	Letters	Fight	Endure	Deceive	Letters
Survive the Wild	Wayfaring	Wayfaring	Endure	—	Notice
Disputation	Letters	Letters / Persuade	Will	Deceive	Empathy
Contest of Names	Mysteria	Mysteria	Will	Deceive	Letters
Bargain	Persuade	Persuade	Will	Deceive	Empathy
Rite Against Rite	Mysteria	Mysteria	Endure	Deceive	Letters
Intrigue	Deceive / Persuade	Persuade / Intimidate	Empathy	Deceive	Investigate

Disputation

A formal debate before an audience — a council of bishops, the Academy, a Gothic king's hall. Its stakes are what the audience *believes* when it ends. Losing a Disputation before a church council can make you a heretic.

Contest of Names

This setting's **Spirit Duel**: two magi or a magus and a spirit, each trying to name and compel the other. Knowing the opponent's true name gives +1 on every action. The loser's compromise is usually *enthralled*, *shaken* or a Debt.

Bargain

Negotiation with something that does not need you: a fae lord, a god, a Lamia matron. The side that loses its Disposition **owes a Debt** (weight 1–3, set by the compromise) as well as the normal outcome.

Rite Against Rite

Two Rites working against each other — a binding and a release, a ward and a summoning. Each side's Disposition is its Rite's clock: Attack removes the opponent's segments, Defend holds your own. When one side's clock empties, its Rite fails and the other completes.

Intrigue

Court politics run over days or weeks: each exchange is a week, a feast, a session of the Senate. Use the core rules for long conflicts. The prize is an office, a marriage, a verdict or a ruin.

Chapter 12: Scene Truths

These Truths join the core list. Create them with Momentum, Woe or Effects as the core rules allow.

Truth	Effect
Holy Ground (patron)	Hieratica of that patron +1 Power. Blood-drinkers who enter take *shaken-2*.
Threshold	See **Thresholds and Iron**. The uninvited must pay 2 Wœ to cross.
Thin Place	Crossing into the Veil is Standard. Rites here need 2 fewer segments. Dread +1 tier.
Cold Iron Present	Long Night fæ can't use Specials within reach of it.
Solstice Tide	The Stone Throne turns. The Court that holds it gains +1 on all rolls in the Veil.
Day of Blood	The eve of the vernal equinox. Mormo's rites need half the segments.
Witnessed by the Faithful	Magic in public is one step harder, and the Church hears of it.
Plague-Rot	Endure rolls are one step harder. Mormo's servants are +1 here.
Under My Roof	Guest-right. Harming host or guest makes the attacker *forsworn-3*.
Banner of Parley	No Attack actions. Breaking it makes the breaker *forsworn-3*.
The Lamps Gutter	Too much magic in one place. Mechanica rolls fail on doubles.
Veil-Fog	Sight is one step harder; resonance travel is Standard.
Drowned Shore	The Order of Dagon's ground. Hybrids +1; the sea is listening.
Marked by the Sign	The Yellow Sign is drawn here. Brotherhood workings +1 Power; Dread +1 tier.
Sigesis	A Gnostic silence. Hieratica can't detect anyone here; prayers go unheard.
Uneasy Nights	Region Truth where the walls grow thin. Shared dreams; rest restores 1 less in each pool.

Part 4
Appendices

Chapter 1: A Campaign Primer for Players

> "The world is ending. It has been ending for a hundred years. And somewhere, beneath the rot, something is waking up and calling it an opportunity."
>
> — overheard in a tavern in Ravenna, attributed to no one

How to Read This Primer

This primer is written for **players**, in the voice of the world rather than the rules. Everything here is knowledge your characters could plausibly have — the shape of the world they live in, the folklore they grew up with, and the rumours a well-travelled or well-connected person might have collected about the hidden powers that move beneath ordinary life.

It is deliberately incomplete. Much of what follows is *rumour, folklore, and hard-won hearsay*, presented the way your characters would actually encounter it: as fragments, warnings, and traveller's tales rather than settled fact. Some of it is wrong. Some of it is half-right in dangerous ways. The truth of these things — what they really are, what they really want, and how they really work — is the story you are going to discover at the table.

When this primer says *"it is said"* or *"they whisper"* or *"the folklore claims,"* treat that literally. Nobody has handed your character a verified encyclopedia of the supernatural. They have handed you the map that superstitious, frightened, clever people have drawn in the dark.

The World You Live In

Rome is gone.

Not forgotten — not yet. The roads still work. The law is still cited. Latin is still the tongue of court and contract from Ravenna to Constantinople. Senators still meet in Rome. But the legions that held the frontier for five centuries are mercenary warbands now, paid in land and promises, loyal to kings with names like Theodoric and Clovis rather than to any emperor. The Western Empire died in the lifetime of your grandparents, and most people are still quietly waiting for it to come back.

It isn't coming back.

The world in 500 AD is a patchwork of successor kingdoms, provincial holdouts, and border zones where no single power can guarantee you safe passage from one city to the next. The Ostrogoths rule Italy from Ravenna, and their king Theodoric governs with a competence that makes some Romans nostalgic and others uneasy. The Franks are consolidating Gaul under a king who recently converted to Christianity — whether out of faith or politics, no one agrees. The Vandals hold North Africa and the great grain-city of Carthage. The Visigoths hold Hispania and the south of Gaul. The Eastern Empire endures in Constantinople, rich and intact, presiding over theological arguments so bitter that neighbouring bishops have had each other murdered over the exact nature of Christ's divinity. Persia watches from across the Euphrates, patient as it has always been.

This is a world in motion. Everything is provisional. Everything is up for grabs. Old borders have dissolved and new ones have not yet hardened. A family that was powerful under the Empire may be beggared now; a warband captain's grandson may hold a city. Trust is local, loyalty is negotiable, and a letter of introduction is worth more than a sword on most roads.

Three faiths contend for the soul of this world. **Nicene Christianity** — the faith of Rome, Constantinople, and the newly-converted Franks — is ascendant and increasingly intolerant of rivals. **Arian Christianity** — a different reading of Christ's nature — is the faith of most of the Germanic kings, the Goths and Vandals, and so the ruler and the ruled often pray in different churches. And beneath both, the **old gods** have not entirely died: in the countryside, in the mountains, in the harbours and the mar-

ket-towns, people still leave offerings at the crossroads and the hearth, still fear the wrong festival observed the wrong way, still know the names their grandparents warned them not to say after dark.

And the hidden world — the one your characters are about to become entangled in — is *more visible* than it has ever been, or may ever be again. When the great institutions weaken, the things they used to hold at bay come closer to the surface.

What Your Characters Know About the World

The Supernatural Is Real

This is not a matter of debate for people of this age. The gods are real. Spirits walk alongside the living. Prayers sometimes work. Rituals performed correctly produce results that cannot be explained by philosophy or medicine. The question is never *whether* the supernatural is real — only *what kind* of real it is, and whose version of it is pointing at you right now.

When your character encounters something impossible, they will probably be frightened. But they will not be paralysed by the proof that magic exists. They already knew it does. What they won't be ready for is the *scale* of it — the sense, in certain places and certain company, that the world is far larger and far stranger than any priest or philosopher has ever admitted.

The Shape of Reality, as People Understand It

Educated people — theurgists, philosophers, the more learned clergy — speak of reality as having layers. The everyday world, the world of flesh and stone and sunlight, is the one everyone lives in. Alongside it, or beneath it, or just behind it, is a **spirit-world**: the realm the theurgists call the *Apokryphon* and that ordinary folk know as the Otherworld, the realm of the Fair Folk, the place beneath the hill, the country of the dead and the dreaming. It is real, it is inhabited, and in certain places — old barrows, deep forests, the thresholds between one thing and another — the border between it and the waking world grows thin.

And beyond even that, the folklore speaks of something further out and further down: a **beyond** that has no comfortable name. The philosophers call it the Outer Dark; the frightened call it many things and prefer not to. Most people never think about it at all, and are better for it. It is the place the oldest prohibitions exist to keep shut. You do not need to understand it. You need only understand that some of the powers in this primer are very interested in it, and that this interest is the single most dangerous thing about them.

The Old Laws

There is a persistent belief, shared across many traditions that otherwise agree on nothing, that the world is held together by a small number of very old **laws** — prohibitions, really, rather than descriptions. There are things that must not be done. Gates that must not be opened. Names that must not be spoken in a certain order. Bindings that must not be broken. The folklore numbers these prohibitions differently depending on who is telling the story, but a recurring figure is **seven**.

Nobody agrees on where these laws came from. Some say the gods set them; some say something older than the gods. What everyone who takes them seriously agrees on is that breaking one is not like breaking a human law, where the harm is local and the punishment comes after. Breaking one of the old laws is understood to do damage to the structure of the world itself. This is why the beings who enforce them (see *The Keepers of the Seals*, below, and *The Seven Seals* in Part II) are so grimly humourless about it.

Magic Is a Discipline, Not a Gift

Magical ability can be trained. It requires talent, yes — but talent without training is dangerous to the practitioner and useless to anyone else. The traditions that have survived to 500 AD each have their own method, their own costs, their own limits.

- **Priestly magic** is borrowed power. A priest works wonders not from her own reserves but from what her patron deity has granted her. She is only as powerful as her god's favour — and gods, it turns out, can be displeased, distracted, or simply weakened. When a god's power wanes, so does the priest's, often without warning and never at a convenient moment.
- **Theurgical and philosophical magic** is slow, precise, and ceremonially demanding. The scholars who practice it spend years learning to name things exactly right — to know the true and proper name of a thing, and to speak it in the correct order, with the correct preparation. When it works, it is the safest form of working. When it fails, the failure is usually instructive rather than catastrophic.
- **Sorcery from darker traditions** is faster and dirtier, drawing on chthonic powers and half-understood names. It works more often than it should. The cost is usually paid later, and by someone who didn't agree to the terms. Many a village has a story of the cunning-man whose bargains came due.
- **The language of the most ancient things** — words borrowed from beings older than the gods — should not be spoken aloud. Even scholars who know what they are looking at will not write them down. If you find a text that uses them, burn it. The burning will not help, but it is the correct impulse.

A Note on What Magic Costs

Every tradition agrees on one uncomfortable point: power comes from somewhere. It is not free, it is not infinite, and it is not created out of nothing by good intentions. The priest borrows and must repay in service. The theurgist spends years and hours and health. The sorcerer defers the bill and someone else pays it. Whenever a character is offered power that seems to cost nothing, the correct response is not gratitude. It is suspicion.

The Hidden World: A Traveller's Guide

What follows is gathered from rumour, tavern confession, the marginalia of burned books, and the hard-won testimony of people who survived encounters they couldn't explain. None of it is certain. All of it matters. Where this guide states something as fact, understand that it is stating what people believe — and people, especially frightened people, are frequently wrong about exactly the things that matter most.

The Keepers of the Seals

"They move through the world as scholars, physicians, and itinerant teachers. You've probably met one without knowing it."

Somewhere between a wizard's guild and a secret court of law, there exists an organisation so old it predates most of the empires currently arguing over its territory. It doesn't have a widely-known name — or rather, it has many names, none of them the right one. Its members appear in the world as academics, physicians, court philosophers, and teachers at the great schools of Alexandria, Athens, Nisibis, and Toulouse.

What they actually do, as near as anyone outside can tell, is enforce the old laws — the prohibitions described above. There are things that must not be done, and the Keepers have appointed themselves (or been appointed by someone) to see that they aren't. They investigate rumours of forbidden workings. They confiscate dangerous texts. They intervene, sometimes lethally, when someone gets close to opening something that should stay shut. They have been doing this for a very long time, and they are serious about it in the way that only people who have personally seen the consequences can be.

Their enforcers are visible, if you know what to look for: grey-cloaked figures carrying iron swords that have been treated with consecrations to cut through enchantment. They are called, in various whispered traditions, the Stylites, the Grey Hoods, the Ash-Cloaks. If you see them moving quickly through a city with purpose and no luggage, something nearby is about to be investigated.

They are not the villains of this story. They are also not always right about who is. They are cautious, bureaucratic, and slow to trust, and their caution has occasionally let a real horror grow while they debated jurisdiction. But when they decide to move, they move decisively, and they do not much care whose plans they interrupt.

What you might need from them: They can identify magical threats, authenticate artefacts, and occasionally sanction operations that would otherwise constitute a violation of their own rules. They move slowly and bureaucratically — until they don't.

What they might need from you: Deniability. Speed. The willingness to go somewhere their public role won't let them go, and to do something they cannot be seen to have ordered.

The Blood Courts

"The old families of Rome are still here. Some of them are very, very old."

There are, by the reckoning of those who study such things, four known courts of beings who sustain themselves on what mortals possess and they do not. They are not unified. They are not coordinated. They are, in fact, deeply suspicious of one another — old rivals with long memories and longer grudges. But they have all negotiated some form of accommodation with mortal society, and that accommodation is precisely why you need to know they exist before you accidentally violate its terms. The fastest way to die in this world is to break a rule you didn't know was there.

The noble houses of the desert hold administrative offices in the Vandal court at Carthage and in the old towns of Egypt. They look like powerful, eccentric patricians of the newly-arrived ruling class. The folklore about them is specific and worth heeding: they are said to be *paralysed by thresholds* — a properly maintained hearth-shrine, an intact doorway-ward, will stop them at your door as surely as a wall. They keep bound servants — sometimes called cup-slaves — who are wholly, wretchedly addicted to their masters' attentions and will do anything to remain in favour. If a powerful Vandal official makes you uncomfortable in a way you can't articulate, and the local household shrine has been subtly defaced, leave the building and do not return after dark.

The old families of Rome are exactly who they appear to be — patrician dynasties with Senate seats, estates, and centuries of accumulated influence. What sets them apart is what they feed on: not blood, but *emotion*. Cultivated fear. Sustained desire. Curated despair, savoured slowly. Their victims are never drained dry, because a dead victim feeds no one; they are managed like vineyards, kept alive and productive for years. If a particularly charming and well-connected household has been attentive to you for weeks, and you find yourself feeling inexplicably worse every time you leave their company — hollowed out, diminished, obscurely afraid — examine your situation very carefully, and consider who benefits from your unhappiness.

The mountain dead of the eastern provinces do not pretend to be alive. In the highlands of Dacia and the Carpathian passes they are known plainly as the walking dead — apex predators to be left offerings and given a wide berth. The folk remedies against them are old and consistent: they are said to be turned by running water and thresholds, repelled by garlic and by certain consecrated things, and destroyed by the sun, which they cannot endure. They are also said to be bound to their native earth, unable to travel far from the soil of their own graves. If you travel in those hills and the locals begin leaving bread and a covered bowl at the crossroads at dusk, do not mock them. Find an inn and bolt the shutters.

Something from the far east moves through the steppe and the silk-road corridors, and the little that is known of it is known mostly through the care people take to avoid it. Sogdian merchants sometimes carry written notes they will not read aloud, left for them in specific locations by parties they have never seen and do not wish to meet. Those who have brushed against this power and lived speak of a killing that comes from a distance, without a

mark, without a touch. The Keepers' advice, arrived at (one suspects) through hard experience, is simple: do not initiate contact. Do not offer gifts. Do not ask questions. Whatever it is, it is old, it is patient, and it is best left entirely alone.

The Twilight Courts

"There are two kinds of darkness: the darkness that waits, and the darkness that was. Do not confuse them. The first will bargain. The second simply is."

The spirit-world — the Otherworld, the *Apokryphon*, the realm of the Fair Folk — is real, it is inhabited, and the beings who rule its deeper reaches are very, very interested in the specific wording of your promises.

Two courts divide the deep Otherworld between them. Each is ruled by a sovereign figure spoken of as three-women-and-one: the **Maiden**, the **Queen**, and the **Crone**, three aspects turning through a single throne like the turning of a year. One court is often called the **Winter Court** — ancient, cold, precise, and merciless. The other is the **Summer Court** — warm, beautiful, generous-seeming, and no less precise. Do not mistake either warmth or cold for kindness. The seasons are how they present themselves to mortals; the appetite beneath is the same.

The fundamental thing to understand about the Fair Folk is this: they cannot lie. This is not a virtue. It is a constraint — and they have become extraordinarily skilled at misdirection, technical truth, flattering ambiguity, and omissions that lead you exactly where they wanted you to go while every word they spoke was true. Every clause in a fae bargain is a loaded mechanism. Every debt compounds. A favour accepted without clear terms is a debt without a ceiling, and they are endlessly patient about collecting.

The lesser folk — the sprites, the river-nymphs, the household spirits that live in hearths and mines and crossroads — are more accessible and considerably less dangerous, *provided you observe the correct protocols*. Milk left at the threshold. Bread at the mine-entrance. Silver at the crossroads. A clean hearth and a civil word. These are not empty superstitions; they are the terms of small, ancient contracts that have kept villages safe for generations. Disrupting them — mocking them, skipping them, letting the offering-bowl go dry — has consequences that your priest will not be able to explain and your neighbours will blame on you.

The Church names most fae dealings as diabolic. This is not entirely wrong: the entities offering midnight bargains in lonely places are often the Winter Court acting as debt-collectors, and their gifts damn as surely as any devil's. It is also not entirely right, in the sense that those same debt-collectors are, by some accounts, part of the reason certain *other* and worse things have not yet eaten your village. The situation is complicated. In this world, it usually is.

The Sea Covenant

"We made a bargain with the sea's people at the time of our grandfathers' grandfathers. Our nets have never come empty since. We do not speak of it."

In the port cities of the Phoenician coast — particularly ancient Sidon — there is an order of navigators, fishers, and harbour-pilots who have operated continuously for longer than recorded history. They are not a religion. They have no doctrine, no creed, no missionary impulse. They have a *covenant*.

The covenant involves the sea, and the sea involves things that live in it — things that are very old, very patient, and interested in the shoreline in ways that have never been fully explained to anyone who wasn't already party to the bargain. Those inside the covenant prosper. That is the whole of what outsiders reliably know, and even that they mostly infer.

You will know the families involved by their prosperity: boats that don't sink, catches that don't fail in years when everyone else goes hungry, harbour-pilots who know currents no chart records. And you may notice, in the *older* members of these families, something harder to name — a certain quality to the skin, a width

and flatness to the eyes, a too-long reach of the fingers, a strange resistance to cold. They favour high collars and long sleeves. They do not discuss it, and there is something about them that makes it difficult to look directly, difficult to remember clearly, difficult to ask the obvious question.

They are not aggressive. They are patient. They accumulate — wealth, influence, and, over generations, families. If you find yourself investigating strange disappearances in a coastal community — people who walked into the water at night and did not return, always at certain seasons — examine how prosperous the town is, and for how long the prosperity has lasted, and whether the disappearances and the good fortune began in the same generation. Then ask, carefully, whether the harbourmaster's hands have always looked that way.

The Wandering Scholars

"There are scholars who observe without worshipping, record without distorting, and refuse all patrons. I have met two in my life. Both made me feel I was a letter being read aloud by someone who already knew the ending."

There is something watching the world that does not appear to want to rule it. They pass as scholars, physicians, and administrators — competent, unremarkable, easy to overlook — but something is slightly *off*. They read at speeds that should not be possible. They tilt their heads at exactly the same fifteen-degree angle when considering a problem, every one of them, as though it were a shared habit learned in the same unimaginable school. They show an unusual indifference to sleep, to food, to fear. They ask questions about your grandmother's death, and about the exact sequence of small choices that led to a decision you made seven years ago — and they write nothing down, because they do not need to.

If you encounter one, they will want your *testimony*. Not your soul, not your service, not your silence, not your worship — your testimony. They want to know what it *felt like*, from the inside, to be present at a consequential moment. They will ask thorough, patient, uncomfortably precise questions. They will be unfailingly polite. And they will not tell you why any of it matters.

Do not make binding agreements with them. They measure time on a scale that makes a human lifetime an afternoon, and an offer you make today may be treated as still open when your great-grandchildren are old. What was a favour to you will be, to them, one clause of a single unbroken conversation.

If you ever need something from them — and occasionally you will, for they know things no one else has bothered to remember — the only leverage that works is your own irreplaceability as a witness. They cannot be bribed, threatened, or flattered. They can, however, be *drawn* by the prospect of testimony they cannot obtain any other way. Be careful what you trade. You will not understand the price until much later.

The Hidden Faithful

"They burn our books so they cannot be read. They burn our teachers so they cannot be heard. Yet the fire they kindle from our texts warms the very room in which they interrogate the next one of us."

There is a network of cells — not a church, not a cult, not a mystery religion in the usual sense — scattered across the Mediterranean from Alexandria to Edessa to the villages of the Faiyum. They are the survivors of a tradition so old and, in the eyes of the dominant Church, so dangerous that the most powerful religious institution in the world has been trying to eradicate them for four centuries. They are still here. Barely.

They are, by any honest count, losing. Each generation is smaller than the last. Their sacred texts are buried in sealed jars in the Egyptian sand, hidden from the fires. Their teachers meet in the back rooms of textile shops, in the wagons of trade caravans, in cellars and catacombs. Most remarkably of all, one branch is said to have embedded itself so deeply into the official Church hierarchy that some ordained clergy — men who preach orthodoxy on Sunday — are quietly initiated

members of the very thing they are meant to be stamping out.

What they teach — the portion of it that constitutes their public doctrine, the part they will share with an outsider they are testing — runs roughly thus: *the living world is not as it appears.* The power that demands exclusive worship and brooks no rivals is not what it claims to be. And the remarkable man the Church has raised into a god was, they say, in truth a *mortal* — a teacher who discovered something extraordinary about human potential, something his followers understood and his enemies worked very hard to bury.

They are not interested in converting you. They are interested in whether you are *capable of perceiving* what they perceive — whether you can look at the world and see the seams. If you can, they will find you; the approach is patient and sometimes involves a staged series of uncomfortable trials designed to learn whether you panic and betray your companions under pressure. If you fail those tests, you will simply never hear from them again.

They are worth finding. The things they know are worth the risk of knowing them. Whether they are *right* about all of it — about the world, the false power, the mortal made god — is a question the truth of your campaign will answer in its own time, and not before.

The Wandering Dark

"Mormo is feared and shunned outside the circle of her devotees. Signs of her passage: the wolf that stalks the infirm, cancerous growths in the flock, the deer blinded by flies hatching in its eyes."

There is something that wears the face of fertility, and it is one of the most feared names in this primer.

It moves through existing religious communities — particularly those built around motherhood, growth, the harvest, and the female divine — and it hollows them out from the inside, so that a rite meant to bless the fields becomes something else while the worshippers still believe they are doing what their grandmothers did. It has been doing this, the folklore insists, for longer than Rome has existed.

It has no central organisation and requires none. Its scattered cells share only a willingness to conduct certain rites and a devotion to a power that is nourished, apparently, by *corruption* — by the rotting and the dying, the tumour and the blight, the spreading of things that should not spread. Where it passes, the folklore says, the land itself sickens in small wrong ways before anyone understands why.

Its wandering priestesses are often women who have left legitimate religious roles under difficult circumstances — the disgraced, the exiled, the bereaved who were promised something in their grief. They travel as wandering performers, beggars, and theatrical folk, and they are hunting: for the grieving, the wronged, the desperate, and the curious. They are very, very good at finding them, because those people are always, in every village, easy to find.

Signs of presence:

- Livestock developing tumours and strange growths, especially in early spring
- A traditional fertility festival that has become subtly *wrong* in ways the participants cannot quite articulate
- Wandering performers who linger in a village a little too long and leave it somehow changed
- The vernal equinox — a day some whisper of as the *Day of Blood* — observed with an intensity that makes the older residents deeply uncomfortable

The cults that hunt this thing wear the blue of the Madonna and count it their sworn enemy. The Keepers track it. Neither has ever managed to destroy it. It thrives wherever a civilisation rots, and the fifth century — a century of collapse, plague, famine, and despair — has given it more to feed on than any age in living memory.

The Brotherhood of the Open Gate

"They do not want power. They do not want gold. They do not want to rule the world that is.

They want to open the door and let in the world that comes after. Pray you never meet one who is sincere."

Of all the rumoured powers a traveller might hear of, this is the one the wise fear most — because it is the only one that does not want *anything you could bargain with.*

The other hidden powers of this world, for all their appetites, mostly want to *keep* the world: to feed on it, rule it, prosper within it, endure inside it. This one is different. The Brotherhood — it goes by no single name, and the names it does use are best not written — is said to be a scattered brotherhood of scholars, priests, and sorcerers who have concluded that the world as it is should *end*, and who labour patiently across generations to bring that ending about. They are the ones who study the old prohibitions not to enforce them, but to learn how to break them. They are the reason the Keepers of the Seals never truly rest.

They are subtle. They do not announce themselves. They work through respectable men — a learned priest, a wealthy patron of the arts, a scholar with an unusual library and an unusual patience. They collect forbidden texts. They seek out the sealed places and the buried names. They are willing to spend a lifetime setting up a single ritual their grandchildren will complete, because to them a human lifetime is merely a convenient unit of labour toward an end that does not care about time.

What, precisely, they are trying to *open* — and what they believe waits on the other side — is not something any sane person claims to know, and the few texts that describe it are exactly the texts one is advised to burn on sight. It is enough to know this: if you ever cross a conspiracy whose members seem to want nothing you can give, refuse nothing they can safely refuse, and pursue some incomprehensible goal with serene, generational patience — a goal that seems, the more you learn of it, to be *worse for everyone including themselves* — you may have found them. Take what you have learned to the Keepers of the Seals, and do not investigate further alone.

Signs of presence:

- A learned or wealthy man of good reputation with an inexplicable interest in sealed ruins, forbidden texts, and the oldest and worst names
- A ritual site being prepared with enormous care and no apparent purpose that benefits anyone
- The sudden, quiet interest of the grey-cloaked Keepers in a person or place you had thought entirely ordinary
- Scholars and clergy dying, or vanishing, along a line that seems to point somewhere on a map

A Few Last Words of Advice

For your character, embarking on this world, the accumulated wisdom of everyone who has survived it comes down to a handful of rules:

- **Assume the rules are real.** The offering at the threshold, the ban on the certain name, the festival done exactly so — these customs exist because people who ignored them died. You will not know which superstition is load-bearing until you break it.
- **Free power is the most expensive kind.** Everything in the hidden world runs on exchange. If a thing offers you strength, safety, wealth, or knowledge and names no price, the price is simply one you haven't been shown yet.
- **Words are weapons and words are chains.** Especially with the Fair Folk, the Wandering Scholars, and anything that offers a bargain. Say less than you want to. Promise nothing you have not read three times. And never, ever, agree to terms you do not fully understand.
- **The Church is powerful, sincere, and often wrong about the details.** It will name many different things "devil" and treat them alike. Some of those things are worse than devils. Some are, in a strange way, on your side. Learn to tell them apart, because your priest cannot.

- **When you are out of your depth, you are probably still underestimating how deep it is.** The scale of this world exceeds what any one person can safely know. The characters who last are the ones who learn to recognise the moment to stop pulling the thread — and to find someone older, wiser, or better-armed before they pull it further.

The world is ending. It has been ending for a hundred years.

What you do in the ruins is up to you.

This primer contains only what your characters could plausibly know: the shape of the world, the folklore, and the rumours. The truth beneath the rumours is the story you will discover in play. Trust nothing here completely. That, too, is part of living in the Aetas Obscura.

Names in This Primer

The Primer uses the names ordinary people use. The rest of this book uses the names the hidden world uses for itself.

In the Primer	Elsewhere in this book
The Keepers of the Seals	The Concord of the Seven Seals; its grey-cloaked enforcers are the Stylites
The old laws	The Seven Seals of Solomon
The Blood Courts	The Four Sanguine Courts: the Hounds of Set, the House of Lamia, the Strigoi of Dacia, the Court of Jade Breath
The Winter and Summer Courts	The Court of Long Night and the Court of the Burning Crown
The lesser folk	The Free Folk
The Sea Covenant	The Esoteric Order of Dagon
The Wandering Scholars	The Yithian Archive
The Hidden Faithful	The Gnostic Apokryphon
The Wandering Dark	The Cult of Mormo; its fœs are the Marian hunters
The Brotherhood of the Open Gate	The Brotherhood of the Black Pharaoh
The spirit-world, the Otherworld	The Veiled Sphere

Chapter 2: Glossary

- **Akosmoi, Daimones** — "the un-worlded ones"; the Outer Ones.
- **Anabasis** — the Gnostic ascent through the archons.
- **Apokryphon** — (1) the Veiled Sphere; (2) the Gnostic Apokryphon.
- **Concord, the** — the Concord of the Seven Seals; the wizards' council.
- **Concordat, the** — the treaty among hidden powers, sealed 287 BC.
- **Debt** — a favour owed to a hidden power, weight 1–3.
- **Drujān** — "the Lies"; Persian name for the Outer Ones.
- **Enthralled** — the status of a blood-drinker's or sorcerer's thrall.
- **Exōthen** — the Outer Dark.
- **Favour** — a priest's standing with a patron; spent on Hieratica.
- **Forsworn** — the status of an oath-breaker.
- **Free Folk** — fae of neither Court.
- **Goeteia** — fast, name-binding sorcery of the papyri.
- **Hieratica** — priestly magic: power borrowed from a patron.
- **Honestiores, humiliores** — the honoured and the humble under Roman law.
- **Hoi Exō** — "those outside"; the Outer Ones.
- **Kosmos** — the mortal sphere.
- **Magia** — the fire-and-word of the Mobedān.
- **Mobedān** — the Zoroastrian magi of Persia.
- **Mysteria** — the skill of magic and rite.
- **Nemesion** — the Outer taint.
- **Paranomos** — a lawbreaker magus.
- **Pneuma** — breath and will; magical potential.
- **Sigesis** — the Gnostic silence that hides one from the gods.
- **Stylite** — an ash-cloaked enforcer of the Concord.
- **Sword of Damocles** — probation for a first-time Seal-breaker.
- **Theurgy** — Neoplatonic ritual magic; the Concord's art.
- **Twilight Courts** — Long Night and the Burning Crown.
- **Veiled Sphere** — the spirit world.
- **Woe** — the GM's pool.

Chapter 3: Quick Reference

Five Campaign Truths

Devotion Has a Cost · Names Have Power · The Seals Are Walls · Thresholds and Oaths Hold · The Dark Is Patient.

Breaking a Seal

GM +2 Woe · the walls thin · *nemesion-1* (VII: *–2*) · Stylites clock ticks if noticed.

Workings

Cantrip 12 · Operation 15–21 · Theurgy 24 as a Rite. 1 Pneuma (Dabbler 2). Outside Domain: one step harder, 2 Pneuma, any doubles backlash.

Rites

Clock 6 / 8 / 12. Untrained +4 segments. Thin Place –2. Kyphi +1 on the first roll.

Offerings

Own blood: –2 Sōma, +1 die · Animal: +1 segment per success, +1 Woe · Willing life: +3, Seal I, *nemesion-1* · Unwilling life: +4, Seals I and IV, *nemesion-2*, +3 Woe.

Patron States

Starving (one step harder) · Waning · Steady · Waxing (+1 Power) · Bloated (+1 Power; doubles: no answer).

Dread

Shaken (Pneuma) for fear · *unmoored* (Psychē) for knowledge. Tiers 1–6 by exposure. Familiar horror –1 tier.

Debts

Weight 1–3. Refuse a called Debt: *forsworn* at twice the weight.

Stations

Outcast · Servile · Common · Lettered · Honoured.